

## RECTUM, ANUS, AND DEFECTION

The rectum is around 12cm (5in) long. Below it is the anal canal, about 4cm (1½ in) long. In the walls of the anal canal, there are two sets of strong muscles – the internal and external sphincters. During defecation, peristaltic waves in the colon push faeces into the rectum, which triggers the defecation reflex. Contractions push the faeces along, and the anal sphincters relax to allow them out of the body through the anus. The defecation reflex may be aided by voluntary contraction of the abdominal muscles, or overridden by conscious control.

